

BEFORE

Kingdoms and empires rose and fell in India in the centuries before the Sultanate.

THE GUPTAS

The Gupta Empire (320–540 CE) **124–25** was a **period of stability and prosperity**. It ran from present-day Bangladesh to eastern Pakistan.

HARSHA

In 606 CE **Emperor Harsha** established a **powerful empire** across much of northern India. After his death the empire **fragmented into small kingdoms**.

THE CHOLAS

The **Chola Dynasty** (850–1200 CE) ruled all of south India. The empire was a crucial staging post for **Chinese and Arabic merchant ships**.

ISLAM BEFORE THE DELHI SULTANATE

Arab traders had introduced Islam to the region by the 8th century, and there were incursions by Muslim armies from **Persia** and **Ghazni** (modern Iran and Afghanistan) in the 8th–11th centuries. Islam's impact at this stage was still very limited.



CHOLA BRONZE

The Delhi Sultanate

Although Islam was present in parts of South Asia from the 8th century, the establishment of the Delhi Sultanate (1206–1526) marked a new era. Immigrants from Central Asia and Persia brought concepts of kingship, built cities, and founded empires. India was incorporated into the cultural scope of Islam.

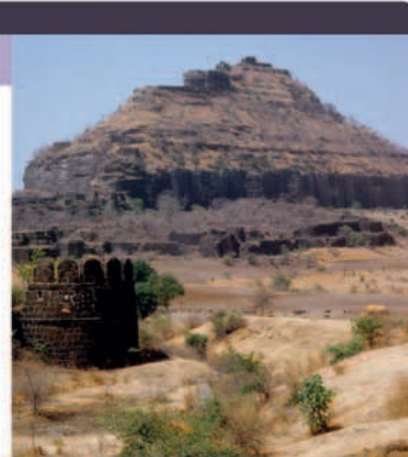
In 1175, the nomadic Muslim chieftain Muhammad of Ghur (in present-day Afghanistan) advanced into India. Although the Indian armies were bigger and richer, the nomads had the advantages of horses and a centralized army. Sweeping eastward over modern-day Turkistan, Pakistan, and northern India, Muhammad's armies sacked Delhi in 1193.

After Muhammad of Ghur's death in 1206, one of his generals, the ex-slave Qutb-ud-din Aibek, gained control of his territories in India and established the Delhi Sultanate (kingdom). To celebrate this and to symbolize the assimilation of new territory into the wider Muslim world (see pp.174–77), he began to build what would become the tallest minaret in the world—the Qutb Minar. This 238-ft (72.5-m) tower came to symbolize the sultanate. As the empire expanded, successive sultans sought to demonstrate their power by building grand monuments around it.

DECISIVE MOMENT

DECCAN REBELLION

In 1345, the governors of the south Indian Deccan provinces revolted against Delhi. The sultan's army defeated the rebels, but some managed to escape and regroup. When the sultan left to quash a rebellion in Gujarat, the Deccan rebels seized their chance and defeated the imperial army. Their leader was declared Sultan Alauddin Bahman Shah at Daulatabad Fort (right) in 1347, establishing the Bahmani kingdom. This was the end of the Delhi Sultanate's expansion, and the start of its long decline.



Sultans and slaves

The early sultans ruled over a fragile kingdom, and their authority was concentrated in a series of fortified towns. The nomadic tribes who made up the nobility did not have a strong tradition of hereditary kingship. Military slaves frequently became sultans, such

as Iltutmish in 1211 or Balban in 1266. Women, too, could become sultans if they could muster the support of the nobility, as Razia Sultana did in 1236.

Succession to the throne at Delhi was often secured through violence; during the Slave Dynasty (1206–90)—the first dynasty of the Sultanate—at least five



India 750–1450

The territories of the many kingdoms and empires of medieval India ebbed and flowed over time. This map highlights the areas where the major states of the period first originated.

KEY

Core areas of principal states

